shining brightly outside and jumped out of bed thinking I had overslept only to find everyone else fast asleep. I wandered about the house, finally waking my mother up, who told me to go back to sleep, as it was still the middle of the night. That was my introduction to geography and the phenomena of the 'midnight sun' when close to the Arctic Circle. Another fact that I clearly remember is the long, straight stretches of the highway—AutoRoute—and my father telling me that it was made by design so that in an emergency it could be used as an airstrip. That was in the late 1960s; we would do the same in India some four decades later.

In the third year, we went down south to Italy, stopping at Florence, Rome and Venice, via Nice and the French Riviera. We saw all the masterpieces of Leonardo da Vinci and Michelangelo, not to forget the Trevi Fountain, where I tossed a coin into the water and silently mouthed, 'I wish I . . .', a wish which was to come true. My father dragged us from museum to museum exclaiming, 'This is world famous . . . that is world famous', till quite exasperated, I plaintively responded, 'Daddy, can we see something that is not world famous?' At one such museum, I was so exhausted that I dozed off on an ornate chair and a few visitors thought I was part of the exhibit until I was rescued by my mother. My mother used to have a tough time keeping all of us together and fed at regular intervals. I do wonder how much time she got to see all these wonders, while always on the lookout for the three of us. At Venice, we had the obligatory gondola ride, just as a shikara ride is mandatory for anyone visiting Srinagar, and saw all the other sites made famous in the mystery thriller *The Da Vinci Code* by Dan Brown. And, of course, the first taste of pizza, while sitting at a roadside trattoria. On the way back, it was through Switzerland and Austria, catching the sights, sounds and smells

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